

ISLANDS ARE ECOLOGICAL SYSTEMS

ISLAND BIOGEOGRAPHY

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURES

Robert H. MacArthur (1930–72), **Edward O. Wilson** (1929–2021)

BEFORE

1948 Canadian lepidopterist Eugene Munroe suggests a correlation between island size and butterfly diversity in the Caribbean.

AFTER

1971–78 In the US, biologist James H. Brown studies mammal and bird species variety on forest “islands” in the Great Basin of California and Utah.

2006 Canadian biologists Attila Kalmar and David Currie study bird populations on 346 oceanic islands and discover that species variety depends on climate as well as area and isolation.

Island, or insular, biogeography examines the factors that affect the species richness of isolated natural communities. Charles Darwin, Alfred Russel Wallace, and other naturalists had written about island flora and fauna in the 19th century. Their studies were conducted on actual islands in the ocean, but the same methods can be used to look at any patch of suitable habitat surrounded by unfavorable environment that limits the dispersal of